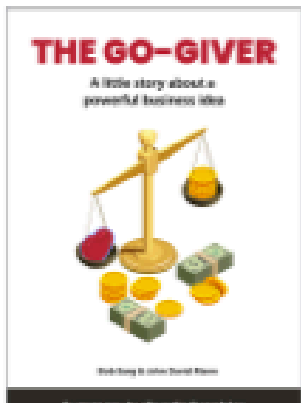




THE GO-GIVER

A Little Story About
A Powerful Business Idea

BOB BURG AND JOHN DAVID MANN

The Big “So What”



In a brutally competitive world where everyone seems to be fighting to earn more and achieve greater success, this book offers an alternative set of business success principles built on giving and adding value to others. These laws were originally written to help businesses to increase sales and profits, but were found to also improve relationships and success in life.

The Story



The Go-Giver is a fable about an ambitious young man, Joe, who propelled himself to phenomenal success after he learned and applied the “Five Laws of Stratospheric Success”.

Joe was a true go-getter—diligent, efficient, and dedicated—yet frustrated that he could not achieve his goals despite his hard work. One day, desperate to close a major sale to meet his quarterly targets, he sought the advice from a famous consultant, Pindar.

He was surprised to discover that Pindar’s secret to making money and growing his business was to give sincerely. Pindar offered to mentor Joe, on the condition that Joe would personally test and apply every one of the lessons he was taught.

Over a week, Pindar introduced Joe to several “go-givers”, including a restaurateur, a CEO, a financial adviser, and a real estate broker, who jointly shared the details of the 5 laws. By the end of the week, Joe had learned the power of giving, and understood that by putting others’ interests first and continually adding value to their lives, you could eventually generate unexpected returns.

KEY QUOTES

“While the world may at times appear to be a dogeat-dog place, there is actually a set of much kinder and vastly more powerful principles operating beneath the surface of casual appearances.”

“To get really, really big, to reach the kind of stratospheric success we’re talking about, people need to have something on the inside, something that’s genuine.”
- Pindar from *The Go-Giver*

The 5 Laws of Stratospheric Success



Most people are hesitant to give because they are afraid of being taken advantage of. However, people tend to treat you the way you expect to be treated, so it becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy.

Giving first is like adding logs before expecting the fire to burn, or putting in your capital before expecting to get interest. You need to give first to receive later.



1. The Law of Value

Your real worth is defined by how much more value you give than how much you get paid.

Before thinking about profits, first ask yourself, does this serve others? When you focus on giving value as a way of life, the money will naturally follow.



In the story, Pindar introduced Joe to restaurateur, Ernesto lafrate, who started with one hot dog stand and grew his empire to include multiple restaurants with several hundred millions worth of real estate. Ernesto shared the secret behind his phenomenal success, which was to deliver incredible value to his customers. He explained that:



A bad business aims to give the *bare minimum* quantity and quality of goods and services to customers, to justify the money it's being paid.



A good business aims to give the *most possible* quantity and quality of goods and services, for the money received from customers.



A great business aims to deliver *unbelievable value*, offering such high quantity and quality of goods and services that it's almost unreal.

KEY QUOTES

"Ultimately, the world treats you more or less the way you expect to be treated."
- Pindar from The Go-Giver

"Appearances can be deceiving... they nearly always are."
- Ernesto from The Go-Giver

"If you need money, add value. And if you need a lot of money, add a lot of value."
- Pindar from The Go-Giver

After going back to his office, Joe tried to find ways to apply the lesson. The next day, he received a call from a client who has decided not to renew his contract as his company needed a firm with stronger overseas connections. Although Joe was upset, he put the Law of Value to use by recommending a competitor who could meet the client's needs.



2. The Law of Compensation

Your income is decided by the number of people you serve and how well you serve them.

The first law defines how valuable you are, and thus your *potential* to make money. **This second law decides how much impact you make, and therefore how much money you actually earn.**



In the story, Joe was next introduced to Nicole Martin, the young, dynamic and creative CEO of a company that marketed learning programs to schools globally. Nicole was formerly a grade school teacher who was frustrated with the limited impact she was making. When she developed a learning system for children, she was able to extend her reach beyond her classroom. As she scaled her system and related products, she reached thousands of children, and eventually adapted the system for corporate executive training as well. As the reach and impact of her business grew, so did her profits.

This law is fully within your control:



You can decide how many people you want to serve and how big an impact you want to make.



You can even change your limiting beliefs, e.g. doubts about your ability to create a big impact and achieve huge success. You're the only person who can hold yourself back.

When Joe returned to his office, he tried to apply this rule by personally serving coffee to each of his colleagues, all of whom were pleasantly surprised by this gesture.

KEY QUOTES

*"Your compensation is directly proportional to how many lives you touch."
- Nicole from The Go-Giver*

"Money is not a measure of your goodness or worthiness; it is a measure of your impact."



3. The Law of Influence

Your influence is defined by how often and how much you focus on others' interests first.

This law is about giving freely, rather than keeping score of when or how you help people.



The idea of “win-win”, or having a fair 50-50 split in benefits for both sides, only works in theory. In reality, the best way to build strong relationships is to focus 100% on helping the other person, without keeping track of how much others owe you or how much they gain.



Most people wrongly believe that you gain influence through wealth, status and success. In reality, the reverse is true—influence brings wealth, status and success, and **the most influential people are those who give and add value to others.**



When we help someone, it's common for us to think or say, “you owe me one”. If you can help someone without strings attached, you become truly attractive as a person, and this naturally increases your influence.

In the story, Joe next met Sam Rosen, Nicole's financial advisor. Sam started out as a struggling insurance salesman, but gradually built a good reputation and began to attract bigger cases. He eventually became a top salesman and offered a broad range of financial advisory services, before starting to work with non-profit organizations and became one of the top philanthropists in his state.



Sam explained that his success came not just from giving great value, but also on developing a huge network. Sam defines a network as “people who are personally invested in seeing you succeed”. They may not be your customers and may never even buy something from you. However, they like you and want you to succeed.



When you have a huge network, you essentially have an army of personal ambassadors.

KEY QUOTES

“Forget win-win—focus on the other person's win.”
- Sam from The Go-Giver

That night, Joe returned home to find his wife, Susan, feeling troubled about work. Typically, their norm was to each take no more than 30 minutes to share about their day. Joe decided to listen fully to Susan, giving her his full attention without keeping track of the time or their usual “rule”.

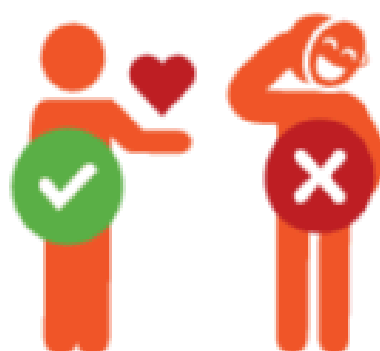
To his surprise, Susan was so touched by the gesture that she left him a note the next morning to thank him for making her feel more loved and heard than she had in a long time. Joe started to realize that the laws also apply outside of business, to one’s relationships and personal life.



4. The Law of Authenticity

The biggest and most valuable gift you can offer is yourself.

Every human being craves genuine connections and relationships. Hence, **the best gift you can offer someone is your authenticity, simply by being yourself rather than pretending to be someone else.** No amount of manipulation skills or techniques can be as effective or valuable as your authenticity and sincerity.



To learn about Law 4, Pindar brought Joe to a symposium by Debra Davenport, the city’s top realtor in residential and commercial markets.

 During the symposium, Debra shared how she suffered from low self-esteem after her husband left her. She was unable to get a job, and failed to make progress in real estate despite learning all sorts of sales and closing techniques.

 Ironically, she made her first breakthrough when she wasn’t trying to close a sale. That was when she realized that the biggest value she could offer was to be authentic and sincerely connect with people around her. Achieving success involves 90% people skills and only 10% technical skills.

While Joe found the laws and lessons to be intriguing, he was no closer to meeting his quarterly targets and wondered if he was wasting his time. Back in his office, he bumped into Gus, the

KEY QUOTES

“No matter what your training, no matter what your skills, no matter what area you’re in, you are your most important commodity. The most valuable gift you have to offer is you.”
- Debra from The Go-Giver

*“You want people skills?
Then be a person... It’s called authenticity.”*
- Debra from The Go-Giver

top performer in his company, and the two men had a brief chat. Joe shared openly about his encounters with Pindar and the go-givers, as well as his worries about his quarterly targets.

He was surprised to realize that Gus was the very person who had connected several of the go-givers many years ago, and that Gus had been applying the 5 laws to achieve his massive success.



5. The Law of Receptivity

To give effectively, you must be open to receive.

Most of us have been taught that it's better to give than to receive. However giving and receiving are 2 sides of the same coin. **There can be no act of giving without a concurrent act of receiving**, just like how you cannot exhale without inhaling.



 This law is often the hardest for most people, as we've been conditioned to see altruism and self-interest to be mutually exclusive. However, when you're not open to receiving (e.g. if you feel bad about receiving a favor or rejects someone's help), you are actually stopping the flow of giving and receiving.

 The next time someone pays you a compliment, simply receive it graciously by saying "thank you" with a smile. This could be your first step to applying this law.

After learning all 5 laws, Joe found himself feeling less anxious about his quarterly targets, even though he had made no real progress since he first approached Pindar. That Friday evening, as he was reflecting on his situation in the office, he received a call from the competitor he had referred his client to. It turned out that there was an once-in-a-lifetime business opportunity that his competitor couldn't fulfill, and he was contacting Joe for assistance.

What goes around comes around. That was how Joe became a partner in a coffee business and went on to achieve stratospherical success.

KEY QUOTES

*"Every giving can happen only because it is also a receiving."
- Pindar from The Go-Giver*

*"If you don't let yourself receive, you're refusing the gifts of others—and you shut down the flow."
- Pindar from The Go-Giver*



Other Lessons from the Story

Besides the 5 laws, Joe also learned several things by observing the go-givers.



As he met each business-owner, he was struck by how gracious, friendly and polite each of them were in spite of their successes, and how they all exhibited an intense, magnetic quality. Later on, he realized that it was the Law of Influence at work—by giving unselfishly, they became more attractive as individuals.



He also learned about the powerful life philosophy adopted by Rachael, the lady who eventually partnered with Joe to grow a huge coffee enterprise.

- Survive-save-serve. Rachael was always full of zest for what she did, even if she didn't always enjoy the task. This was because she was always grateful for the chance to *survive* (i.e. meet her basic living needs), *save* (i.e. have excess resources to expand her life beyond basic needs), and *serve* (i.e. contribute to others around her).
- Most people focus on surviving, and some on saving. However, the rare ones those who focus on serving often find themselves becoming so successful that the first 2 components naturally fall in place.

Applying the Go-Giver Approach



At the heart of this book is the old maxim, "Give and you shall receive." **The principles may not sound logical, but the only way to test if they work is to apply them**, just like what Joe did. In applying the 5 Laws of Stratospheric Success, here are some useful points to note:



Effort. The go-giver approach is not a magic solution. You still need to put in the effort for your business to work. However, by shifting your perspective and focus, you can achieve greater success and fulfillment.

KEY QUOTES

"Success is the result of specific habits of action: creating value, touching people's lives, putting others' interests first, being real, and having the humility to stay open to receiving."



Patience. The 5 laws may create greater and faster results in the long run, but the results will not be instantaneous. Be patient and give time for the results to kick in.



Profits and achievements. There's nothing wrong with making profits or being a go-getter. The key is to focus not only on profits or on achieving your personal goals. When you focus on giving value to others, you tend to get better results and profits in the long run.



Value is not just about cash or money. You can offer as much (if not more) value to others by giving your friendship, attention, energy etc. This means that anyone—regardless of your business size or financial situation—can be a go-giver.



Giving is not about charity or sacrificing yourself. It's merely about putting aside your self-interest temporarily to focus on others.



By applying these ideas, you can improve not only your business sales and profits, but also the outcomes in your personal life.

Other Details in the Book to Look Out For



After the original book was published, it grew into a movement. Readers started to share how they used the 5 laws to turn around their businesses with more sales and happier customers, improve their marriages and parenting.

This expanded edition of the book was published nearly a decade later, and includes an additional foreword by Arianna Huffington, a new introduction, a discussion guide, and a set of Q&As. For more details, please visit <http://thegogiver.com/>.

KEY QUOTES

"The Five Laws aren't magic; genuine success still takes work, but it becomes work you love."

"There's nothing wrong with making money... It's just not a goal that will make you successful."

- Pindar from The Go-Giver

"A genuinely sound business principle will apply anywhere in life—in your friendships, in your marriage, anywhere."

The Go-Giver started as a book but soon became a movement."